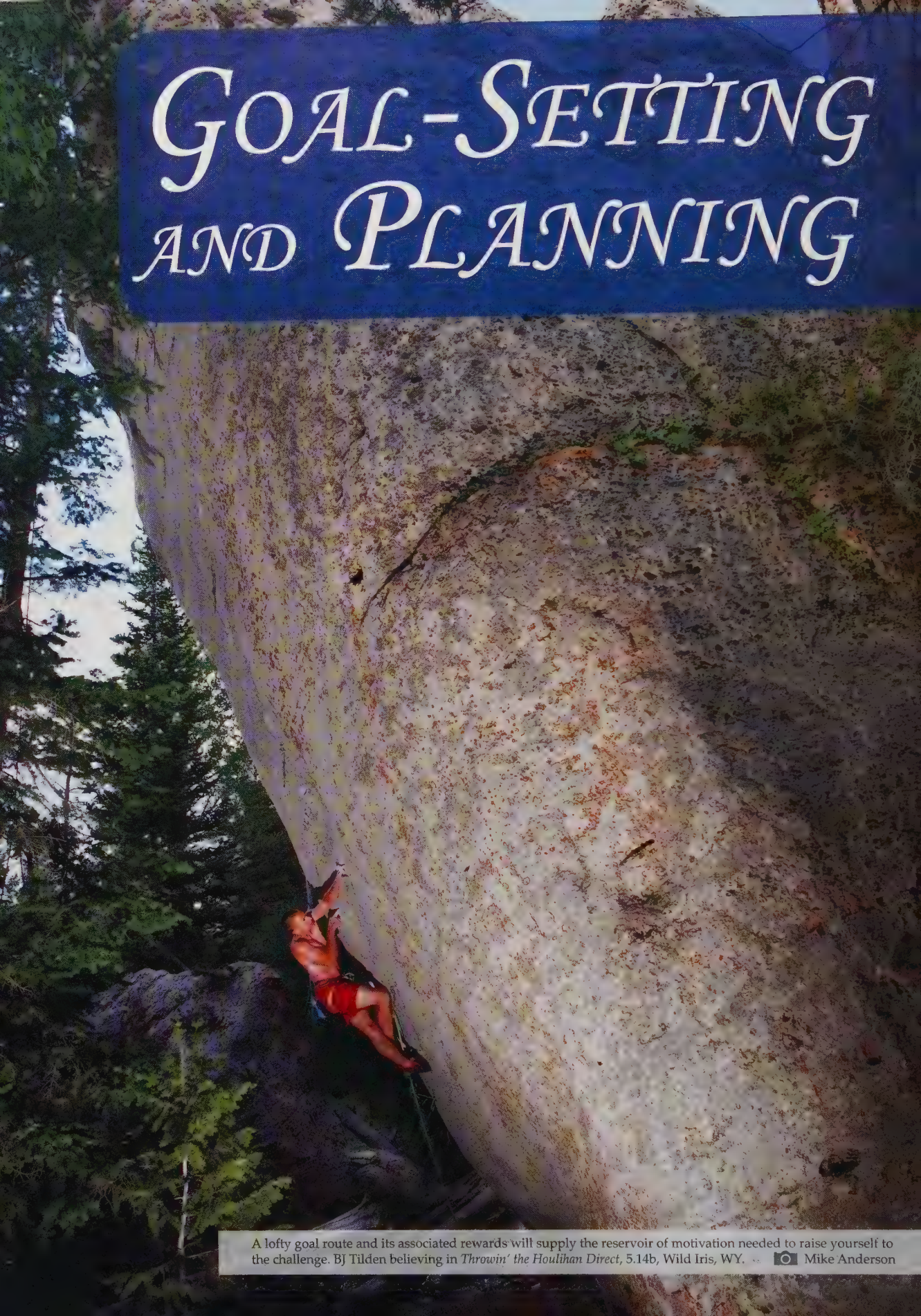


GOAL-SETTING AND PLANNING



A lofty goal route and its associated rewards will supply the reservoir of motivation needed to raise yourself to the challenge. BJ Tilden believing in *Throwin' the Houlihan Direct*, 5.14b, Wild Iris, WY.  Mike Anderson

CHAPTER 2

"All men dream, but not equally. Those who dream by night in the dusty recesses of their minds, wake in the day to find that it was vanity: but the dreamers of the day are dangerous men, for they may act on their dreams with open eyes, to make them possible." — T. E. Lawrence²

Goal-setting has always been an essential tool in athletic pursuits, and possibly all human endeavors. Even chipmunks set out every autumn with the intention of gathering enough acorns to make it through the winter. Goal-setting is just as important in climbing. Goals create focus, steer the training plan, and provide motivation when the going gets tough.

The first step in achieving any great feat is to identify the primary objective. That's the easy part, though it presents some pitfalls as well (more on this to come). With the primary objective defined, one can identify the gaps between the desired end-state (the goal) and the present state. Next, it becomes a relative formality to lay out a plan, complete with intermediate goals, for moving from the present state to the desired end-state. With a thorough plan and the proper assortment of short-term, intermediate, and long-term goals, the climber has a framework for achieving "the impossible," and specific instructions for how to use each day to move closer and closer to his dream.



Mark Anderson nearing the summit of Denali, 2001.

📷 Mike Anderson

GOAL-SETTING

This approach can and should be applied to all types of climbing, but our climbing roots in the world of mountaineering provide a great metaphor. In mountaineering, the ultimate goal is to get to the summit (and return safely), but on the big peaks this is usually accomplished through several intermediate steps. For example, a typical goal-oriented strategy for climbing Denali might be:

Main Goal:

1. Summit Denali via the *West Buttress* and return home safely

Intermediate Goals:

1. Learn to ski while pulling a sled
2. Learn to ice-climb
3. Practice camping on a glacier
4. Experience climbing above 15,000 feet
5. Experience camping and climbing in subzero temperatures
6. Organize logistics for Denali expedition
7. Climb Mt Rainier via the *Ingraham Glacier*
8. Climb a Colorado Fourteener in winter

Short-Term Goals for Achieving Intermediate Goal No. 1:

1. Procure alpine touring (AT) ski equipment
2. Practice using AT equipment on groomed trails
3. Ski up and down a 10,000-plus-foot mountain in winter conditions
4. Procure sled
5. Practice pulling sled on groomed trail
6. Practice pulling sled on backcountry trail
7. Ski downhill on backcountry trail with 40-plus-pound pack and 60-plus-pound sled

In the above example, there is a main goal, a set of intermediate goals, and a subset of short-term goals that lay the foundation for achieving the main goal. While the main goal might seem overwhelming in scope, the short-term goals are relatively attainable, could be accomplished in a single weekend, and help propel the climber directly toward achieving the main goal. Additionally, each subgoal, once attained, contributes to the climber's growing confidence, so when it comes time to take that final leap from the ski plane onto the Kahiltna Glacier, the climber will feel well-prepared for the upcoming challenges.

The Value of Goal-Setting

"I always have a goal in mind when I am training." — Jerry Moffatt³

Over the ten years or so that I've really focused on improving my rock climbing, I've had several great seasons, several terrible seasons, and many mediocre seasons. I've had great seasons that followed great training, subpar seasons that followed great training, and great seasons that followed subpar training. The one consistent aspect of all my great seasons was that they each started with a grand goal.

In August 2008 I decided I would go "all in" to redpoint *To Bolt or Not to Be*, an extremely technical 115-foot wall of tiny edges. Having a specific goal allowed me to tailor that season's training specifically to the route. I ordered a slew of tiny crimps for my home climbing wall, increased my emphasis on skill development, added a closed-crimp grip to my strength training routine, and built several thin, balancey boulder problems to practice on. I planned my entire season around this specific goal, arriving at Smith with fitness perfectly designed around the route. On the seventh day of work, I clipped the chains on America's most legendary sport climb.

At this point I can usually predict if a season will be "good" or "bad" based on the quality of the goals I set for the season. In my experience, training for the vague goal of "general fitness" is a surefire path to disappointment. Despite this, we are often reluctant to establish hard goals, because we are reluctant to commit to the hard work and sacrifice they require. Furthermore, any truly challenging endeavor will carry a significant risk of failure, and we are often afraid to face that demoralizing possibility. Yet while it may be risky, establishing a solid goal is almost always worth the effort it inspires. Even if superficial "success" is not realized, the personal growth experienced is in and of itself a more than sufficient return on the effort invested.

— Mark Anderson

"...To flash my enemies' routes, have them fail miserably on mine, and be the example of sexual perfection to their women."

— Todd Skinner, paraphrasing Conan the Barbarian's take on the meaning of life

THE MEANING OF LIFE

It is common to nurture a "network" of goals, including some that compete with other goals in the network, and others that are complementary. Whether it is deliberately stated or not, most people have an overarching goal to live a satisfying and joyous life (or something along those lines). This overarching goal is the genesis of many other primary goals, such as to have a loving relationship with another person, to have children, to sustain a successful career (or earn enough income to support one's chosen lifestyle), etc.

Success in climbing also supports the overarching goal, but more often than not it seems to compete with the other primary goals. To that end, any climbing goal should be considered with these other primary goals in mind, since they will directly impact each other. Furthermore, the amount of time and resources available to pursue climbing often depends directly on other, seemingly competing primary goals. For example, an otherwise unfulfilling job may produce the funds necessary to support an extended road trip. This understanding can make uninspiring tasks (like going to work on Monday) more meaningful and, ultimately, tolerable. At the same time, keep in mind that any climbing goal that significantly undermines another primary goal is self-defeating — success in climbing should *enhance* a climber's life, not degrade it. If this balance becomes disrupted to the point that climbing progress interferes with your overall happiness, you'd be wise to reconsider your priorities.

Accepting that success in climbing is only one part of a larger puzzle, how should a climber go about achieving "success in climbing"? This is a personal question with a wide variety of "correct" answers. Many climbers are entirely satisfied by simply climbing regularly with good friends in a beautiful setting. Others find this approach unfulfilling, preferring to approach rock climbing as an athletic endeavor, seeking difficult challenges and aspiring toward continuous improvement. The two approaches are hardly mutually exclusive, and many climbers will find themselves with one foot firmly in each camp.

Most climbers will cultivate a network of climbing goals that includes specific, tangible objectives like:

- To climb a 5.XX
- To climb routes A, B, C...
- To free-climb El Capitan

Along with more ambiguous goals like:

- To improve continuously
- To be able to climb the best routes at each crag
- To be a good all-around climber

These parallel sets of goals should be complementary. In most cases, the first set helps define the standard by which the second set is measured. In other words, there is no empirical way to define a "good all-around climber," but the specific goals provide insight into the climber's meaning of that term. For example, if the climber's specific goal is "to redpoint 5.13 and onsight 5.12, sport and trad," they are hinting that those are their personal thresholds for becoming "a good all-around climber." Ambiguous goals can be the basis for every other goal, but they provide little direction. Specific goals, with concrete criteria for success, are far more effective for guiding day-to-day activities. Both have their place and they should be used synergistically.

LONG-TERM GOALS

Long-term goals can be a primary source of inspiration, and area of emphasis, for many years. The quality of the goal is vital to success (both in achieving the specific goal and in directing general improvement in support of more ambiguous goals). Therefore it's important to select a good goal (or set of goals). There are several factors worth considering when making this selection: How does this particular goal fit into the larger scheme? Is this the ultimate objective, or a stepping-stone to a larger goal? Generally, it helps to start with one or more long-term goals, and work backwards from that point to establish a set of intermediate and short-term goals that support the longer goal. However, selecting an effective long-term goal is not trivial.

First consider this potential long-term goal: "I want to climb a 5.12." This goal (and its cousins, "I want to climb a 5.13, 5.14, etc.") is quite common, but it presents some significant complications. First, grades are subjective, so it can be difficult to know if the goal has *really* been achieved or not (a climber might set out to climb a sandbagged 12b just to be sure, but if she is capable of climbing a sandbagged

12b, she should probably set her sights a little higher). Instead most climbers will select a well-traveled 5.12a. Often these routes are right on the margin between the grades, and are the frequent target of downgrading. Grades are a subjective estimate of difficulty, subject to endless debate and adjustment, making them a poor choice for a specific goal.

Second, the goal lacks specifics. One of the primary purposes of goal-setting is to help define a desired end-state, in order to direct the climber's training plan. "To climb a 5.12" is too generic to provide much useful information. Will "a 5.12" require good pinch strength, improved endurance, or better gear-placing skills? The goal as written could entail anything from a 20-foot horizontal-roof deep-water solo, to a one-thousand-foot sixty-degree slab on marginal gear. These objectives require very different skillsets, and so would require very different paths to improve-

ment. The goal selected should be specific enough to help define the exact skillset of interest.

Finally, how motivating is the goal? Numbers have their place, but most of the time they aren't very inspiring. Climbers are inspired by stunning lines in a beautiful setting, interesting history, and the heroic characters of each generation that made the sport what it is today. The goal should be omnipresent, ready to prop the climber up at moments of weakness. It should be posted next to the hangboard, campus board, and pantry, to remind the climber what he's suffering for.

Grade thresholds can be used as goals, but they should remain in the background (with the other ambiguous goals) because they are too vague to provide specific guidance. Instead, strive to select goals that are as specific as possible, such as a particular route. Once an assortment of routes has been climbed at that grade, the climber can be satisfied that the less-specific goal ("to climb 5.12") has been achieved. The "assortment of routes at that grade" will provide the actionable specifics needed to fuel improvement.

Here's an example of an improved goal: "I want to redpoint (*Lower*) *Heinous Cling* at Smith Rock." First off, any debate about the grade becomes immediately irrelevant. The goal has nothing to do with the grade — they are totally unrelated. A goal is really just a stepping-stone to the next, bigger goal anyway, so what does the number have to do with it? The goal might even be "easier" than something the climber has already climbed, but requires a new skillset or exploits a weakness that, once improved, will provide access to other, more challenging goals.

Next, the style of ascent is defined. The original goal left some ambiguity: Would a top rope ascent, with hangs, count? The new goal makes it clear that the intent is to climb from the ground, on lead, with no hangs or falls, but rehearsal of the moves is acceptable. While a formality to some, other climbers struggle on the lead, so specifying the desired style helps define the challenge in a manner that will guide the creation of intermediate goals.

Finally, a specific route has been identified. Just a few minutes of research will provide a tremendous amount of useful information to help plan a training strategy to achieve the goal. The route is dead vertical, with many small, sharp edges, a few thin pockets, and small footholds. The route requires 60 or so feet of continuous climbing without much rest. Further research might reveal a rough number of hand movements required between rests (which will be helpful

Which is More Inspiring?

This:

5.12b

or this:



Boy Prophet, 5.12b, Smith Rock, Oregon.

 Mark Anderson

The Power of Aspiration

"A dream that is great beyond our abilities, a mountain that is harder than we imagine possible, can make us great in our aspiration to achieve it." — Todd Skinner⁴

Todd Skinner was a big believer in dreams, establishing goals and plans to achieve them, and finally, transitioning from planning to action. His book, *Beyond the Summit*, is an outstanding resource for those looking to achieve the "impossible." Todd knew a thing or two about achieving "impossible" dreams; on no less than three occasions*, Todd succeeded on climbs that other climbers — elite climbers — had studied extensively and declared "impossible."

Todd believed each climber should strive for a continuum of success he referred to as the *Lifelong Ascent*. The purpose of this journey is for each person or team to achieve their *Ultimate Potential*. Ultimate Potential is not a fixed point, nor is it defined in relation to the achievement of others; it is the highest each individual could possibly hope to "ascend" in life.

For those who have their Ultimate Potential in mind, every choice becomes simple: you choose the option that will lead you closer to your Ultimate Potential. Furthermore, this construct encourages climbers to dream big, selecting goals that provide the greatest opportunity for growth, rather than "sure things" that offer the greatest odds of "success." Indeed, even the term *success* has new meaning. Success is defined by the amount of improvement and learning achieved — the quality of the process, rather than whether or not the climber stood on the summit. Truly, if the summit were the only measure of success, it would be easier (and therefore "success" more certain) to hike around the back side of the cliff.

The only possible way to reach your Ultimate Potential is to dream big. The biggest dreams inspire the biggest improvement, even if the summit is never reached. We rarely achieve beyond that which we aspire to do, so select aspirations that will inspire the best possible effort. You may be reluctant to describe your aspirations to others, and that's OK, but they should be in the back of your mind at all times. Your aspirations will propel you toward constant improvement, and fuel an indefatigable search for insights and weaknesses to address. When it's snowing outside and you don't feel like driving to the gym, your greatest aspirations provide the motivation to overcome and persevere. Think about the dream you don't dare to dream, and keep it present in your mind. The "impossible" is achieved more often than you might think.

**First free ascent of El Capitan, first free ascent of Direct Northwest Face of Half Dome, first free ascent of Trango Tower*



Todd Skinner contemplating his Ultimate Potential during the first free ascent of El Capitan.  Bill Hatcher

GOAL-SETTING

when deciding the appropriate endurance training to achieve this goal). This information can be used to determine some focus areas for training. For example:

- Crimp strength on half-pad and smaller edges
- Open-hand strength on one-pad pockets
- Footwork and balance on vertical terrain
- Lock-off endurance on vertical terrain
- Local endurance on full-pad edges
- Skin toughness on finger pads

With a specific route in mind, it's possible to identify the ideal time of year to attempt the climb. This information allows the climber to arrange for partners, request time off from work, and construct a training schedule that will maximize fitness at the perfect time. None of these critical items can be planned properly without a specific route in mind. Further guidance on selecting long-term redpoint projects is given in **Chapter 13: Redpoint and Onsight Climbing**.

INTERMEDIATE AND SHORT-TERM GOALS

The truly grand achievements don't happen overnight. Many take years or decades to realize. Long-term goals like these provide tremendous inspiration, but they can also be so intangible and distant that they provide little concrete direction. Intermediate goals are used to provide immediate guidance and motivation to help the climber progress toward the larger goal. One example might be a climber who just sent *Astroman* (an uber-classic, 10-pitch 5.11c crack climb in Yosemite), but aspires to one-day climb *Freerider* on El Capitan in good style. The journey from her current ability to her long-term goal may take years of hard work. The overwhelming magnitude of the long-term goal may be the larger obstacle. Where does the climber begin?

By comparing the desired end-state (the ability to free El Cap) to the current state, the climber can identify areas that need improvement and develop intermediate goals that address each area. Consider this (un-comprehensive) list of potential intermediate goals:

1. Find a willing and committed partner
2. Bivy on a big wall and haul a haul bag
3. Climb an El Cap route (mixed aid and free)
4. Redpoint a 5.10+ offwidth
5. Redpoint ten mid-5.12 granite trad pitches
6. Onsight five 5.12a granite trad pitches
7. Redpoint *The Eighth Day* (a 5.13a sport route at Rifle, CO)
8. Free *Moonlight Buttress* (a 10-pitch 5.12 crack climb at Zion, UT)

HANGBOARD LOG

		Date: 04/15/11	W/O #: 5
		Temp: _____	Dressed Weight: _____
		Rep Timing: 75 min	Rest Interval: _____
<i>Step Up?</i>			
Y (N)	Exercise 1 Grip: <u>Small Edge Edge</u>	Notes: <u>Warm-up</u>	
	Goal: Set: Resistance: #Reps: Difficulty 1-10: Comments:		
	1		
	2		
	3		
Y (N)	Exercise 2 Grip: <u>MR 2F Pocket</u>	Notes: <u>Tape Ring Finger 1-2</u>	
	Goal: Set: Resistance: #Reps: Difficulty 1-10: Comments:		
	1		
	2		
	3		
Y (N)	Exercise 3 Grip: <u>Small Edge</u>	Notes: <u>Breathe</u>	
	Goal: Set: Resistance: #Reps: Difficulty 1-10: Comments:		
	1		
	2		
	3		
Y (N)	Exercise 4 Grip: <u>Wide Pinch</u>	Notes: <u>Remove A 1-2</u>	
	Goal: Set: Resistance: #Reps: Difficulty 1-10: Comments:		
	1		
	2		
	3		
Y (N)	Exercise 5 Grip: <u>Small Edge</u>	Notes: <u>Tape Index 1-2</u>	
	Goal: Set: Resistance: #Reps: Difficulty 1-10: Comments:		
	1		
	2		
	3		

Some of these goals may be trivial (requiring only a decision to commit), while others may be multi-year endeavors in themselves. The point is to provide specific direction and break up the overwhelming long-term goal into digestible pieces that the climber can believe in. Goals can be subdivided as much as needed to create immediate tasks that seem doable, even if the resulting near-term goal is as simple as going to the climbing gym that day.

SHORT-TERM GOALS

Short-term goals are the least discussed, but perhaps most important of all goals. These are the building blocks of every other successful endeavor. Countless short-term goals are established and achieved every day, but remaining conscious of this process can be helpful when progressing through the day-to-day monotony of a training program, or while performing on the sharp end. Every day of an athlete's life should have a short-term goal, even if it is as simple as to rest (which itself may consist of multiple goals, such as eating and drinking properly, reviewing route beta, and visualizing the next performance opportunity, to list a few).

Each workout session should begin with a few short-term goals. If you're new to this process, it's helpful to write these goals down (see an example log above). The training activities described in **Part II: Physical Training** are presented along with goal-setting strategies for each workout, based on prior perfor-

Planning and Executing a Long-Term Goal

In 2001, we achieved a childhood dream by climbing Denali via the famed and magnificent *Cassin Ridge*. This dream arose in high school, nearly a decade before we finally set foot on the mountain. It took several years before we had the courage to deliberately vocalize this goal, and even then we were still woefully unqualified. Neither of us had traversed a glacier, climbed higher than 14,000 feet, ice-climbed, spent multiple nights snow camping, experienced subzero temperatures, planned or executed an expedition, bivied over 8,000 feet... (our lack of qualifications for such a climb could fill this page). In order to bridge the gap between our current experience and the goal, we laid out a multiyear plan, entailing a progression of intermediate goals, each of which would provide the skills and experience needed for Denali:

Intermediate Goal

Contribution to the Long-Term Goal

Step 1: Climb Mount Rainier

More altitude exposure
Several nights in the snow
Glacier travel experience

Step 2: Climb Moose's Tooth

Alaska Range experience
Seven days of glacier living
Advanced glacier-travel experience
Alpine-ice and multipitch climbing experience

Step 3: Climb El Pico de Orizaba

High-altitude experience (the summit is over 18,000')
Logistical planning experience for a multiweek trip

Step 4: Climb Mount Waddington

Advanced alpine, ice, and mixed experience
Seven more days of glacier living in an isolated range
Far more technically challenging than the *Cassin Ridge*

Step 5: Climb Grade 5 Ice

Margin for error and confidence in ice-climbing skills (expecting the *Cassin* to pose nothing harder than AI4)

It took roughly three years just to complete the intermediate goals, but once completed, we knew we were ready to give the *Cassin* a decent shot. In the end, the *Cassin* was relatively easy compared to the sum of our intermediate goals, which made the route that much more enjoyable.



While striving toward intermediate goals, it helps to keep the big picture in sight: bivy on Moose's Tooth with Denali in the upper left.  Mike Anderson

mance levels. The Log Sheets provided in the Appendix can be used for recording daily training goals. At the crag, establishing goals for each attempt and each day provides improved focus and better results (see **Part III: Performing** for a deeper discussion on short-term goals during the Performance Phase).

The next step is easy: following through with the short-term and intermediate goals, making adjustments as necessary, until the long-term goal is realized. From the summit, with the send in the bag, the climber will have a new perspective from which to spy that next, harder goal.

DEVELOPING A PLAN OF ATTACK

With a set of goals in mind, the next step is to create a plan for achieving those goals. Goals provide tremendous inspiration and motivation, but taken by themselves they can be overwhelming and even confusing. A goal without a plan is a pipe dream. A climber's plan is the link between his current abilities or circumstances, and his goals. Like a traveler going from Point A to Point B, the plan is the road map (or GPS unit) that describes the best route.

"No plan survives first contact with the enemy." — Helmuth von Moltke, German Field Marshall¹

This section will discuss how to develop *Long-Range Plans*, *Annual Plans*, and *Seasonal Plans*, with a brief introduction to weekly and day-to-day planning. When working toward long-term goals, it is best to plan in this order, but the opposite approach can be effective as well (developing individual season plans, then putting them together to develop an annual plan, and so on). Either way, as the good field marshall indicated, planning is an "iterative" process, subject to constant re-evaluation and revision once under way.

SELF-EVALUATION

Before planning for a goal, the climber's starting point must be determined. When it comes to devising the most efficient path from Point A to Point B, a well-defined starting point is just as important as a well-defined finish line. Understanding one's "starting point" comes from conducting a thorough and honest self-evaluation.

Self-evaluation is the process through which climbers identify their *strengths* and *weaknesses*. Among all the skills and abilities required for climbing, a strength is one that the climber performs well (relative to the others), while a weakness is performed relatively poorly. Since most successful ascents require a diverse set of skills, weaknesses are most often the limiting factor in climbing performance. Just as a chain is only as strong as its weakest link, if a climber cannot perform any one move on a route, failure is certain. It is tempting to only work to improve one's strengths, since these skills come naturally and are a source of

pride. However the *Law of Diminishing Returns* prevents an athlete from achieving steady improvement in one area forever. The more time spent developing a given attribute, the more difficult it becomes to improve at it. Therefore, it takes great effort to achieve modest improvement in a single strength, while modest effort can result in great improvement in a weakness. For this reason, weaknesses provide the best potential to achieve significant overall climbing improvement with the least amount of effort. That said, a well-rounded climber should strive to improve both strengths and weaknesses, but she must realize that the greatest return on training investment will come from working weaknesses.

Self-evaluation can be a humbling process, but the knowledge gained can be extremely powerful. This knowledge permits the athlete to target her efforts to the precise areas that will produce the most dramatic improvement in overall climbing performance. Unfortunately identifying one's strengths and weaknesses can be extremely difficult. Often a person's own self-image is skewed by myriad factors, ranging from personal history, to external influences, to self-esteem. Eventually it may be helpful to seek the candid assessment of third parties, but that approach has pitfalls as well. Ideally the climber should conduct her Self-Evaluation using a combination of sources.

Begin by setting aside a quiet time for simple meditation with pen and paper. Considering each style of climbing independently (sport, trad, redpoint, onsight, etc.), identify a set of three or more positive climbing experiences, and determine the attributes of these climbs. Next consider a set of disappointing climbing experiences. Some attributes to consider during this process include:

- Safety Attributes:
 - Type of protection (bolts vs. cams, etc.)
 - Frequency of protection
 - Accessibility (was the objective remote?)
 - Partners (experience, familiarity, skill level)
 - Rock (solid vs. "chossy")
- Rock Attributes:
 - Angle
 - Rock type
 - Hold types (pockets, edges, pinches, etc.)
 - Route length
 - Unusual features (arêtes, roofs, corners)
 - Friction
- Climbing Attributes:
 - Powerful vs. "pumpy"
 - Technical vs. thuggish

- **Abstract Attributes:**
 - Climber's attitude, expectations, mood
 - Aesthetics
 - Audience
 - Quality of "moral" support
 - Environmental conditions (cold, hot, windy, scenery, etc.)

The purpose of this exercise is to identify any attributes that are common to the positive experiences and those common to the negative. If many of the negative experiences occurred on a particular type of rock, or a particular style of climbing, these attributes might offer a clue to a particular weakness.

Climbers are often better at identifying weaknesses in others; therefore, video self-analysis can be used to reduce the bias inherent in the Self-Evaluation. While emotionally detaching from the process (easier said than done), review any available film of yourself climbing, noting moments of fluidity and moments of struggle (ideally, you'll use video from a variety of terrain and climbing styles). Consider the following attributes:

- **General Physical Attributes:**
 - Power
 - Endurance
 - Power-endurance
 - Finger strength
 - Core strength
 - Lock-off strength
- **Technical Attributes:**
 - Footwork
 - Precision
 - Efficiency/economy of effort/movement
 - Pacing
 - Breathing
 - Dynamic movement skills
 - Patience
 - Resting Ability
 - Clipping
 - Ability to "read" sequences or recall beta
- **Mental Attributes:**
 - Confidence
 - Courage
 - Relaxation
 - Focus
 - Hesitation

Now consider whether these attributes change depending on variations in terrain and environment. Variations to consider include:

- Route angle (slabby, vertical, overhanging, horizontal roof)
- Hold type (edges, slopers, pinches, pockets)
- Rock features (roofs, arêtes, walls, corners)
- Environmental (heat, cold, humidity, wind)
- Audience

The third method for self-evaluation is to solicit candid feedback from trusted partners as they have seen the climber at his very best and very worst, and so are in a unique position to provide valuable information. These should be partners that have observed the climber extensively and can give critical thought to this evaluation. It's easy for this exercise to devolve into an endless round of war stories, so establish some structure at the outset and be prepared to take notes. It may help to brief your partner on the process and the purpose of this exercise. Consider providing the above list of General Physical, Technical, and Mental Attributes to get the ball rolling, and reassure your evaluator that the critiques won't be taken personally.

Providing frank and earnest feedback is not easy to do, so set your partner at ease beforehand with a promise to keep this information "off the record." Avoid becoming defensive during this process. Remember, you specifically sought this criticism, and the purpose of this feedback is to stimulate improvement, so thank your evaluator for the assistance. Ask the evaluator to begin with a positive, and then alternate between descriptions of weaknesses and strengths, ending on a positive note. It may help to have the evaluator generate this list prior to the actual discussion, though usually the desired criticism must be coaxed. Keep in mind that even third-party observers have their biases. A partner with tremendous finger strength is likely to overemphasize the importance of this attribute, and so on. Don't protest or argue with the evaluator, but keep these biases in mind once the feedback session is completed.

GAP ANALYSIS

After completing these exercises, the climber should have a laundry list of strengths and weaknesses. Attempt to prioritize these lists in terms of their effect on overall climbing performance, but also consider these attributes with respect to any long-term or intermediate goals. Which physical, technical, and mental attributes will be required to achieve these goals?

What are the specific attributes of your goal climbs (rock type, hold type, steepness, length, etc.)? In many cases you'll discover that your strengths align with many of the attributes required for success, but there will probably also be some required attributes that you lack. Highlight these "gaps" between present ability and desired/required ability. These attributes should become the primary targets for improvement.

For the most challenging goals, most climbers will find that even their strengths will need improvement. Regardless, considering the overarching goal of continuous improvement, most climbers will benefit from improving all attributes (whether they belong to the physical, technical, or mental pillars of performance). Often numerous attributes can be improved concurrently, but the *Gap Analysis* allows the climber to prioritize and focus more attention on the most limiting attributes, or address the specific peculiarities of a particular goal route, such as an unusual type of handhold (monos or pinches, for example) or an unusual feature (like a horizontal roof or leaning arête).

Finally, there is a tendency during your Self-Evaluation to dwell on the negative. It never hurts to be reminded of one's strengths from time-to-time. While there may be significant need for improvement, chances are each climber possesses many positive

qualities. The desire to improve, and the determination to follow through on that desire, is a tremendous strength. These traits have been the foundation of every great climbing achievement — they are more important than finger strength or technical ability — and anyone who's ventured this far can put those down in the "strengths" column. Once you make the decision to pursue continuous improvement, the sky is the limit.

THE ROUTE PYRAMID

The *Route Pyramid* is a visual representation of a climber's "resume" of single-pitch rock-climbing ascents, but more importantly, it is an approach to climbing progression that emphasizes building a broad base of experience on routes that are below the climber's maximum ability. This approach dedicates the majority of time and effort to routes that can be climbed relatively quickly (in a few attempts or after a few days of effort). The repeated pursuit of short-term projects is the best approach to long-term improvement (explained further in [Chapter 3: Skill Development](#) and [Chapter 13: Redpoint and Onsight Climbing](#)). The Route Pyramid can also be used in a number of other ways, including as a powerful gap-analysis tool. The pyramid itself is simply a stack of metaphorical build-



When considering your goal route, identify any distinctive features that can be used to steer the season's training plan. Whitney Boland pinching her way up Block Party, San Vito, Sicily

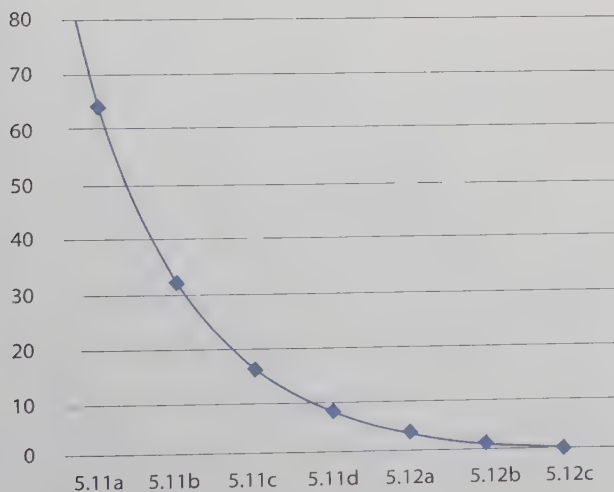
Andrew Burr

ing blocks, with each block representing a successful (free) ascent. The blocks are then “stacked” in ascending rows according to difficulty as shown below.

				5.12c			
			5.12b	5.12b			
		5.12a	5.12a	5.12a	5.12a		
5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d

The classic Route Pyramid for a climber who has completed one 5.12c, two 5.12b's, four 5.12a's, and eight 5.11d's (only the top four levels of the pyramid are shown).

The purpose of the pyramid is to encourage the climber to pursue a broad foundation of experience, with relatively attainable routes, before building up toward more challenging routes. Route Pyramids can have any shape, though the conventional wisdom calls for a pyramid that obeys the function $y = 2^{(x-1)}$. In simple words, the number of ascents doubles for each step down the pyramid. This construct is arbitrary, and mathematicians will note that it quickly becomes unsustainable (climbing one 5.12c would necessitate climbing 64 5.11a's!) as shown in the Figure below.



The same Route Pyramid as above, represented as a logarithmic function

To avoid this problem, climbers should primarily focus on the top four layers of the pyramid. Continue to enjoy routes of all grades, but don't feel compelled to maintain the 2-to-1 ratio between grades beyond the top several layers.

Analyzing one's Route Pyramid allows the climber to quickly identify “gaps” in the structure — areas that may require further emphasis in the future. Consider the examples at the top of the next column:

Uneven Route Pyramids

	5.12c	5.12c
	5.12b	5.12b
	5.12a	5.12a
5.11d	5.11d	5.11d

Climber A

							5.12b
			5.12a	5.12a	5.12a	5.12a	5.12a
5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d	5.11d

Climber B

Climber A's Pyramid is “too steep,” suggesting she favors working difficult projects. This climber might benefit from spending more time on projects she can redpoint more quickly. Climber B's Pyramid is “too wide.” This might indicate that Climber B prefers a “sure thing” — a project he is almost certain to send and can complete very quickly. This climber may benefit from testing himself on more challenging projects in the future.

It can be helpful to track multiple pyramids that represent various styles of ascent (such as sport redpoint, sport onsight, trad redpoint, and trad onsight), since assembling many “blocks” in one style may not adequately prepare the climber to proceed to the next level in another style. Analyzing these pyramids separately may help to identify areas that have been neglected.

Furthermore, ascents completed many years ago may have little bearing on the climber's current abilities. For that reason, each climber should attempt to keep his pyramid “fresh,” by adding new ascents at each grade level each year. It's not necessary to completely rebuild the pyramid from scratch each season (and doing so would consume the season's fitness), but consider beginning each season by adding a block to the lower one or two levels of the pyramid before beginning work on a new block for the top level.

Another benefit of maintaining a Route Pyramid is that by requiring a large volume of ascents, it necessitates climbing a wide variety of features, rock types, and styles. This diversity of experience will help sculpt a well-rounded climber, capable of succeeding on a variety of routes. Initially, it may be possible to select routes that suit the climber's strengths, but once the low-hanging fruit is consumed, the climber will be compelled to pursue routes that exploit weaknesses, thus encouraging further improvement. Climbers who struggle on particular features or rock types can construct pyramids specific to that terrain, thereby build-

ing a solid base of experience from which to improve.

Finally, the Route Pyramid concept encourages the climber to focus the bulk of his effort on routes within his ability. This enables the climber to spend most of his time actually climbing (and therefore improving), as opposed to hanging from a rope while staring at a blank patch of stone.

INTRODUCTION TO PERIODIZATION

Periodization is a strategy for physical training in which different training activities are performed in accordance with a carefully designed schedule. The purpose of this timing is to achieve a synergistic effect on overall performance that results in a *performance peak* at a predictable time. The training strategies presented in this book are designed to be implemented within the framework of a three-to-four-month periodic training plan. For the purpose of the following discussion on planning, this means that each calendar year will consist of a number of deliberately defined seasons (typically three), with each season consisting of several multiweek phases, including *Training*, *Performance*, and *Rest Phases*. Each phase will emphasize a particular type of physical training (such as base fitness training, strength training, power training, etc.).

Chapter 4: Foundations of Physical Training will provide much more detail on this concept and a thorough explanation of its value to climbers.

LEVELS OF PLANS

Just as an athlete establishes several layers of goals (short-term, intermediate, and long-term), it is helpful to establish several layers of plans. Each climber should have a general long-range plan that encompasses the next several years, as well as more specific plans for the current and the coming year. The next layer includes a detailed plan for the current season. Within each season, develop a plan for each individual training session or crag day. Naturally, each plan should become more detailed as the time for implementation approaches.

LONG-RANGE PLANNING

Often long-range plans are vague and ill defined. Most climbers have a general idea of where they see themselves three to five years down the road, but rarely do they have a clear idea of how to get there. Regardless of the scope, any goal is likely to go unfulfilled without a plan. The long-range plan doesn't require extensive detail, but each climber should have a rough idea of

The Long-Range Plan

Remember the climber with the long-term goal of climbing *Freerider*? Suppose she has these other long-term goals as well:

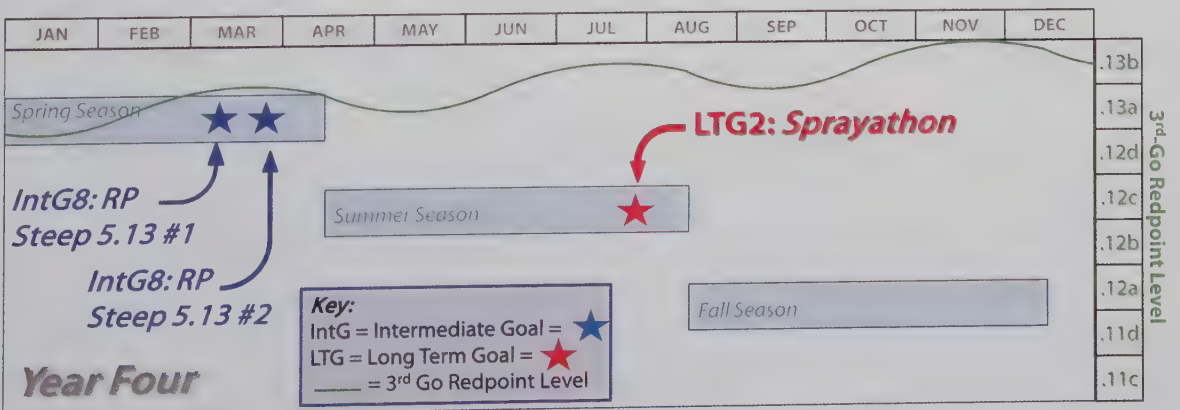
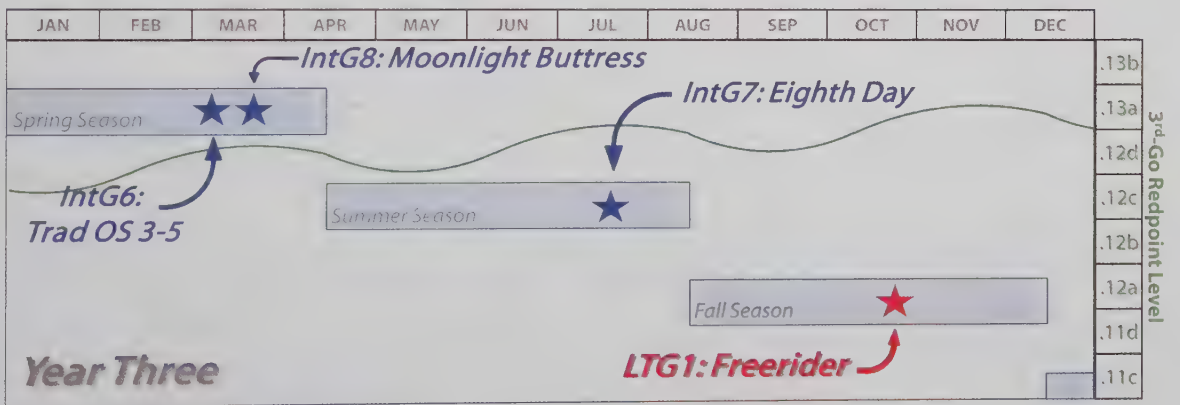
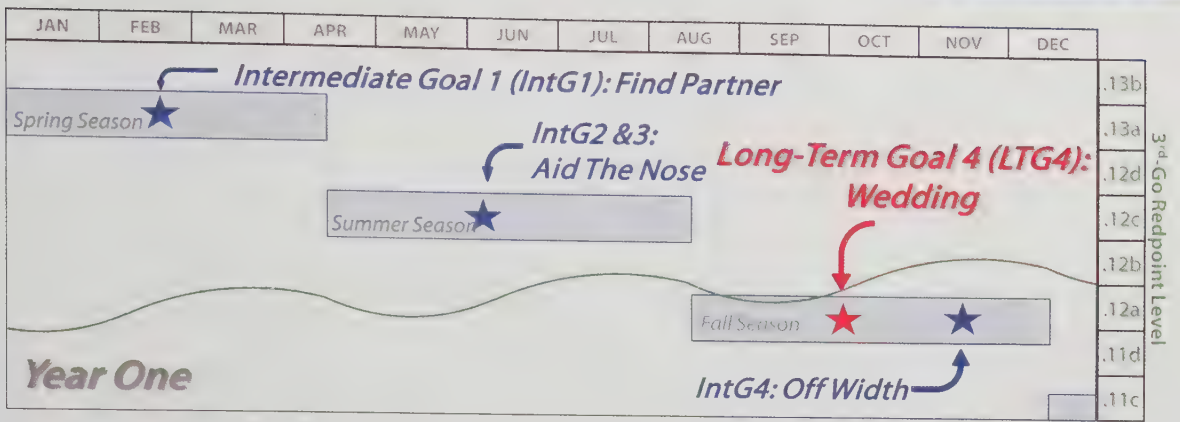
1. Climb *Freerider* in good style (a 35-pitch 5.12d in Yosemite)
2. Redpoint *Sprayathon* (a 5.13c sport route at Rifle)
3. Redpoint *Welcome to Ol' Kentuck* (a 5.13a trad pitch at the Red River Gorge)
4. Marry her fiancé (a mid-5.13 sport climber with commitment issues)

The first step is to determine how these goals relate to each other. Goals 1 and 4 are the highest priority (with a slight edge to No. 1), but goals 2 and 3 are highly complementary, both requiring the same type of fitness (power-endurance). On the other hand, the technical requirements of these goals are very different (to the extent that goal No. 2 will probably require some additional intermediate goals, such as redpointing two steeply overhanging 5.13s on limestone). Therefore, a good prioritization of these goals might be: 1, 4, 3, 2.

While Goal No. 1 is the most important, it is also the most difficult. Goal No. 3 provides a good stepping-stone toward Goal No. 1, so it could be considered an intermediate goal. Goal No. 4 competes with goals 1 and 3, but could be accomplished concurrently with some of the intermediate goals that support Goal No. 1. So a good chronological order for these goals might be: 3, 4, 1, 2.

Our hero currently redpoints most 5.12a trad pitches in two or three tries, and figures she needs to be able to redpoint 5.12d granite trad in about the same number of attempts to have a fair shot at *Freerider*, but would prefer a letter-grade buffer (so, 5.13a). Assuming a conservative improvement rate of one-half letter grade per season, she needs eight seasons (at three-four seasons a year, that's about 2.5 years) to prepare, and she wants her *Freerider* attempt to line up with ideal October conditions (*obviously*, she wants a fall wedding). With all of this information at hand, her long-range plan might look like the example shown in the calendar on the opposite page (the intermediate goals are those suggested in the Intermediate and Short-Term Goals section on p. 28). Note that the "out years" will become more detailed over time.

The Long-Range Plan



how he expects his intermediate and long-term goals to fit into the big picture.

To develop a long-range plan, begin by taking an inventory of all intermediate and long-term goals. Organize these goals into a rough chronological order by considering their relative importance, attainability, and relation to each other. Intermediate goals will facilitate completion of their associated long-term goals, so they should be pursued first. Two or more competing long-term goals might be complementary in some ways, so consider if completing one long-term goal will aid completion of the other (or others), and plan to pursue them in the most logical order. During this process be mindful of other *non-climbing* goals, and how they will impact climbing goals: An impending marriage, birth of a child, or change in employment can have enormous impact on your long-range plan.

ANNUAL PLANNING

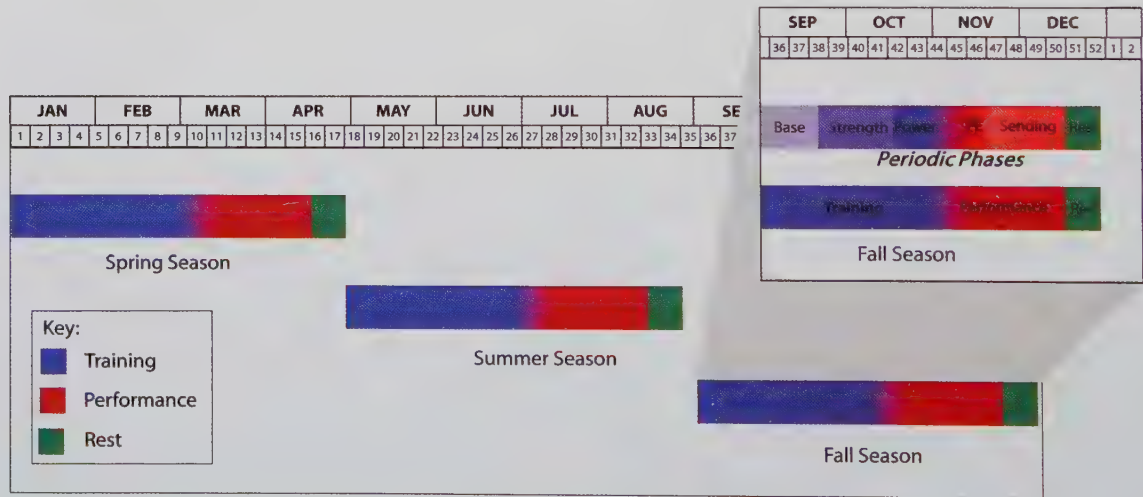
The annual-planning cycle is extremely important to climbers for several reasons: Each season offers distinctly different weather and environmental conditions, so seasons must be matched to certain goal routes (accounting for location and relative priority), such that the ideal seasons are earmarked for the most important objectives. Additionally, external factors like holidays, school calendars, and work disruptions tend to follow annual cycles, resulting in predictable periods that facilitate extra climbing

or interfere with climbing. A good annual plan will consider these factors, allowing the climber to align peak fitness with optimal weather and ample free time.

The lull before the winter holiday season provides a good opportunity to take stock of the previous year and draw up a plan for the coming year. Identify any opportune periods in the coming year (such as three-day weekends, spring break, summer vacation, etc.), and then identify potential non-climbing time commitments (spouse’s birthday weekend, family reunion, business trips, or end of the fiscal year for working stiffs). Lay these out on the calendar.

Next consider any long-term or intermediate goals that will be attempted during the year. Prioritize these (as explained in the Long-Range Planning section) and determine the ideal time period for executing each goal, considering environmental conditions, opportune periods, and time commitments. These time periods will define the *Performance Phases* of each season’s plan. The Performance Phase is the time period during each season in which peak fitness is anticipated — the perfect time for attempting one’s goal routes. Often the process of prioritizing goals will require some difficult choices, in which certain goals are eliminated or put off to the following year, in order to make room for more pressing goals.

Example three-season annual plan



While outdoor climbing occurs throughout a season, periods of peak performance can be reliably predicted. (Note: The seasons are not necessarily placed ideally in this example.)

During this process, consider that more powerful objectives (such as boulder problems and short, burly routes) should be scheduled earlier in the Performance Phase, when the Power Phase has recently ended and your power is maximized. Similarly, relatively endurance-oriented objectives (such as pumpy sport routes or multi-pitch efforts) should be planned for late in the Performance Phase (more on this in [Chapter 10: Building a Training Plan and Other Training Considerations](#)). Power-endurance objectives should be scheduled for the middle of the Performance Phase. Onsighting often depends more on endurance than power, but also relies heavily on technical abilities (such as movement skills and route-reading). These skills tend to be at their peak at the very end of the Performance Phase, after the climber has logged many recent days of climbing on real rock. Therefore onsight objectives should be scheduled for the very end of each Performance Phase. The Figure at the bottom of the previous page illustrates an example of a three-season annual plan.

SEASONAL PLANNING

Once the Performance Phases are identified within the annual plan, the climber should lay out a periodic training plan for each individual season (recommended seasonal training plans are provided, with extensive discussion, in [Chapter 10](#)). The purpose of the periodic training plan is to synergistically build fitness and skill to achieve a peak phase at a predetermined point in the season. This plan will entail several facets of training, including *physical training*, *skill development*, and *weight management* (each of these topics will be discussed in detail later in this book). Climbers with significant fear issues should also consider developing a formal plan for overcoming these issues, which is beyond the scope of this book (refer to Arno Ilgner's outstanding *The Rock Warrior's Way*).

The physical training plan will comprise the following phases of physical training, performed in this order:

- Base-Fitness (2–4 weeks)
- Strength (3–4 weeks)
- Power (2–3 weeks)
- Power-Endurance (2–4 weeks)
- Performance (3–4 weeks)
- Rest (1–2 weeks)

Variations in the prescribed phase lengths will be explained in the coming chapters. The initial climbing-specific training *volume* (a function of training intensity and training duration) will start at a modest level, gradually build through the strength phases, and then taper off as the climber progresses toward the Performance Phase. Likewise, NON-climbing specific training (such as running, cycling, power lifting, or any other form of exercise that contributes minimally to climbing performance) will taper off as the climber enters the Strength Phase, remaining minimal or non-existent through the Power and Performance Phases, then ramp back up during the Rest Phase.

Skill development will also follow a periodic schedule, with early phases emphasizing acquisition of novel skills, the middle phases emphasizing rehearsal and stress-proofing of these skills, and the performance phases requiring execution of these newly



Example periodic seasonal plan

developed skills in high-stress situations. The volume of skill development will also fluctuate throughout the season, with high volume prescribed during the Base-Fitness Phase followed by a lull during the Strength Phase, before ramping back up as the climber transitions to regular outdoor climbing and performance.

Weight management should also follow a periodic schedule. Climbers should aim to reach their lowest healthy weight as they enter the Performance Phase. The Training and Rest phases do not require minimized body weight. In fact, strength training is more effective at a higher body weight. Furthermore, attempting to maintain low body weight indefinitely often leads to sickness or injury, and is not recommended. These various aspects of periodic scheduling are shown in the Figure on the previous page. Once the basic periodic schedule has been developed, you can focus on the detailed planning of each phase. Specific instructions for planning individual phases will be described in detail in [Part II: Physical Training](#).

With a notional seasonal plan in mind, the climber should consider any specific adjustments that might be made to her plan to account for the characteristics of that season's goal routes. For example, if a particular route requires the use of an unusual body position or handhold (such as a mono, split-finger grip, or pinch) to execute the crux, or climbs a type of feature (such as a roof or arête) that is not the climber's strong suit, it may be appropriate to incorporate specific training into the plan to meet these demands. Consider the results of the Self-Evaluation and compare them against the season's planned goal routes to identify any areas that require special emphasis. With this information, you can tailor the season's training toward the demands of the goal route. Much more detail on this tactic is presented in [Part II](#).

DAILY PLANNING

A daily plan is essential to assuring each day is spent in the most productive manner possible. At first this process may seem overwhelming and unnecessary, but with time, each climber will have a small catalogue of standard daily plans to choose from. At that point, the process of planning each day becomes a simple matter of identifying the general objective for the day (for example, to rest, to train power, or to attempt a long-term redpoint project). Certain variables will change (such as the resistance of a given strength-training exercise), but the basic framework can be recycled. The coming chapters will provide detailed instructions for planning training and crag days, complete with suggested daily training routines and schedules for each phase. Armed with these tools, the chore of planning each day becomes a simple matter of placing each training (or performance) activity on the calendar in accordance with the periodic training plan. The chart on the following page shows an example periodic training plan for a novice athlete focused on route climbing (a similar calendar will be presented in much greater detail in [Chapter 10](#)).

Week	Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
-	Last Week of Performance Phase of Previous Season						
-	Rest Phase of Previous Season						
-							Base-Fitness (BF)
1	Base-Fitness (BF)	OAE	BF	OAE	BF	OAE	BF
2	BF	OAE	BF	OAE	BF	OAE	BF
3	BF	OAE	BF	BF	BF	OAE	BF
4	BF	OAE	BF	BF	BF	OAE	Strength
5	Optional Base-Fitness (OBF)		Strength	OBF		Strength	OBF
6		Strength	OBF		Strength	OBF	
7	Strength	OBF		Strength			Power
8			Power		Power		
9	Power		Power			Power	
10	Power-Endurance (PE)			PE			Redpoint (RP) attempts
11	RP			PE			RP
12	RP			PE			RP
13	RP			PE			RP
14	RP			PE			RP/OS
15	RP/OS			PE			RP/OS
16	RP/OS		OAE and/or Optional Training (OCT)		OAE/OCT		OAE/OCT
17		OAE/OCT		OAE/OCT		OAE/OCT	First Day of Next Season

Key:

BF - Base Fitness OS - Onsite

OAE - Optional Aerobic Exercise

RP - Redpoint

OBF - Optional Base Fitness

PE - Power-Endurance

OCT - Optional Cross-Training

Example seasonal training plan showing Performance, Rest, and Training phases, with recommended activities listed for each day. Optional activities are shown in gray text. Note: This example is recommended for an athlete with limited training experience.

Executing the Plan

Creating a plan is only part of the equation. Executing it is another matter, requiring much dedication and hard work. Here are some tips for effectively executing your training plan:

1. Write Down the Training Plan. Do this at a time of rest, when far removed from the discomfort of training. Just like it's a bad idea to shop for groceries on an empty stomach, if you try to make your plan while you are training, you will be fighting the constant temptation to cut corners. Even those with a tremendous work ethic may face a related problem: biting off more than they can chew, leading to injury. Your plan will become your coach, encouraging you to persevere when the going gets tough, and requiring rest once the work is done; this coach feels no pain and has little sympathy for your suffering!

2. Stick to the Plan. As discussed above, we can't be trusted to make changes in the heat of the moment. Granted, every plan needs to be flexible to allow for unforeseen contingencies, but if you find yourself considering a change, think it over for a while, discuss it with other knowledgeable people, and make the decision at a time of rest. Over time, you'll learn to sense when the coach in you is being prudent and when he is cutting corners, but it takes honest evaluation to uncover the true motivations for changing the plan. Once your plan is set, see it through for at least one season before trying something dramatically different. If it's a good plan, you should see results in one season (unless you've been training seriously for many years already).

3. Document What You Did; Use It for Motivation. Often one of the best ways to get the most out of a workout is to have a training partner (or an entire "team" of partners) to work with. This can bring your natural competitiveness to the fight and encourage you to give it your best effort. Few of us have such a partner, and even if we do, it's rare that they are following the same plan, at the same time. The solution is to create a virtual training partner — yourself, from last week, last season, last year, or five years ago. Document the results of your training, use similar training apparatuses from season to season, and then use your previous results as motivation. Keep your training records handy during each workout. While resting between sets, flip through some previous results and see how you compare. This method never fails to motivate me to push a bit harder on the next set. Identify those magical seasons from the past, when everything "came up roses," and use the training benchmarks from those seasons as your target. If you have a training partner, but you are either geographically separated or train at different times of the day, consider sharing your results to create some friendly competition. Just remember, a rising tide lifts all boats — don't let the competition get in the way of your partnership.

— Mark Anderson

HANGBOARD PR LOG SHEET

Grip: <i>MP Thick</i>			Grip: <i>MP Thick</i>			Grip: <i>MP Thick</i>		
Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:
1	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	1			1		
2	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	2			2		
3	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	3			3		
Date	<i>10/10/10</i>		Date			Date		

Grip: <i>Shank</i>			Grip: <i>Shank</i>			Grip: <i>Shank</i>		
Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:
1	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	1			1		
2	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	2			2		
3	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	3			3		
Date	<i>10/10/10</i>		Date			Date		

Grip: <i>MP Thick</i>			Grip: <i>MP Thick</i>			Grip: <i>MP Thick</i>		
Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:
1	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	1			1		
2	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	2			2		
3	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	3			3		
Date	<i>10/10/10</i>		Date			Date		

Grip: <i>Wide Thin</i>			Grip: <i>Wide Thin</i>			Grip: <i>Wide Thin</i>		
Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:
1	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	1			1		
2	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	2			2		
3	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	3			3		
Date	<i>10/10/10</i>		Date			Date		

Grip: <i>IM 2F Pocket</i>			Grip: <i>IM 2F Pocket</i>			Grip: <i>IM 2F Pocket</i>		
Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:	Set:	Resistance:	#Reps:
1	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	1			1		
2	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	2			2		
3	<i>100</i>	<i>10</i>	3			3		
Date	<i>10/10/10</i>		Date			Date		

SUMMARY

- Goal-setting is an essential tool for maximizing climbing improvement.
- Goals should be well-defined and inspiring. Place photos or topos of long-term goals in your training area and use these photos for motivation.
- Short-term and intermediate goals should be established to provide stepping-stones to long-term goals. Establish daily goals for each training session, based on the results of previous workouts.
- A goal without a plan is a pipe dream. Develop a plan (the more detailed, the better) to achieve the impossible.
- Perform Self-Evaluation and Gap Analysis to identify opportunities for improvement. Route Pyramids can be used for Gap Analysis and to develop a broad repertoire of climbing abilities.
- Once a starting point and end point (goal) have been defined, develop a plan to bridge the gap. Multi-year, annual, seasonal, and daily plans can all be beneficial, but expect these plans to evolve over time.
- The Rock Prodigy training program prescribes three seventeen-week seasons per year; each consists of six phases, including Training, Performance, and Rest phases. Use the Seasonal Training Plans provided in **Chapter 10**, or develop your own specific plan.
- The training plan you develop will become your coach. Use it for motivation and restraint at moments of doubt.



Be a climber.

Where you find joy: **pursue it.**

Where you see others finding joy: **encourage it.**

Whatever makes you a climber: **do it.**

These are words.

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